

The Effects of State Paid Leave Mandates on Parental Childcare Time

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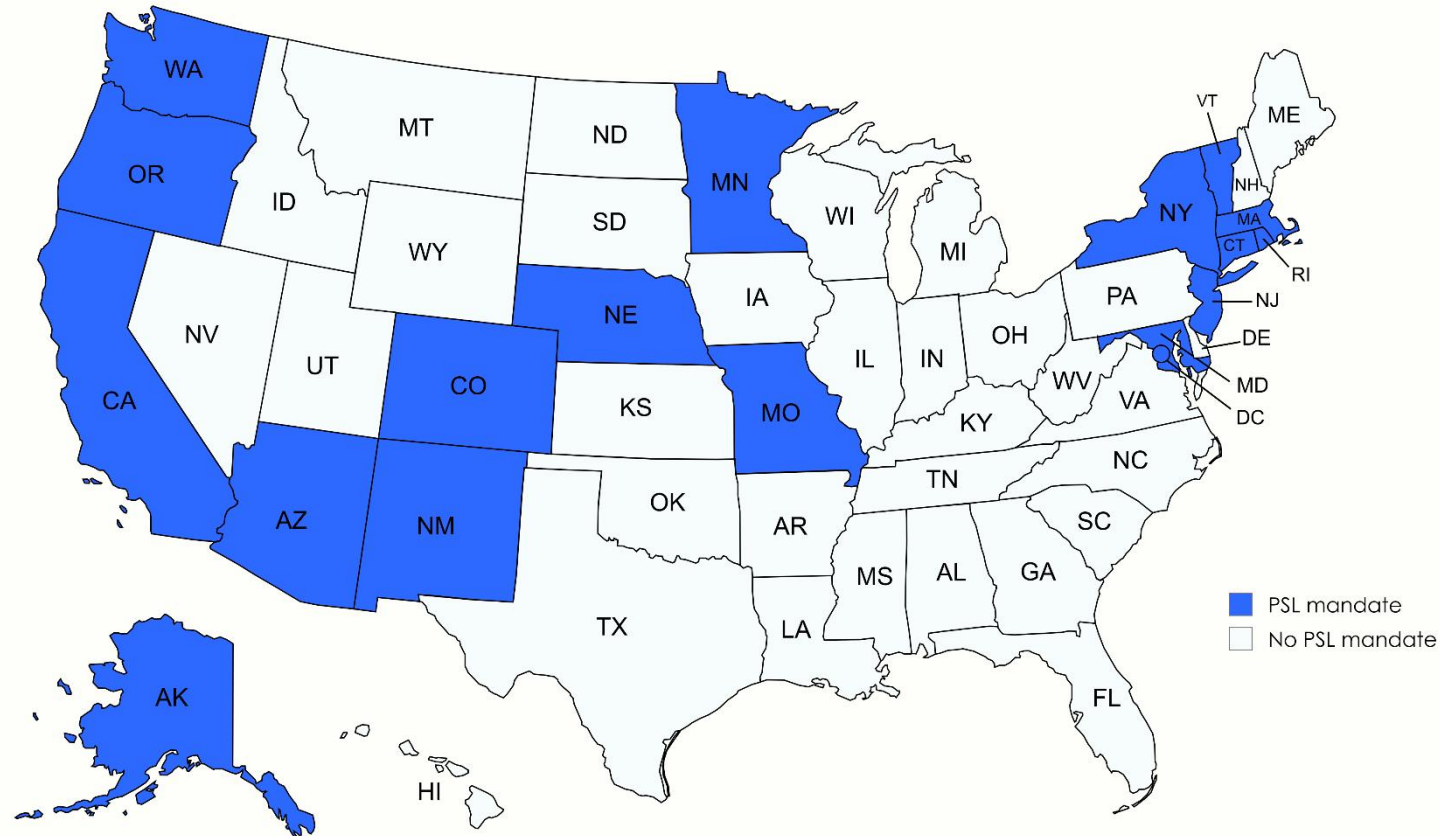


Disclaimer:

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Paid sick leave laws adopted/announced by November 2024



Created with mapchart.net

Source: National Partnership for Women & Families (2025)

Research question

- Do state paid sick leave (PSL) mandates allow parents to take time off work to attend to their children's needs?
 - ▶ State PSL mandates adopted or announced 2008–2024, but exclude small states
 - ▶ American Time Use Survey 2004–2023
- We examine the effect of PSL mandates on:
 - ▶ Work time (first-stage)
 - ▶ Childcare time: Primary, face time, secondary
 - ▶ Household activities, sleep, leisure
- Difference-in-differences (DID) methods and event studies
 - ▶ Compare outcomes in states that do and do not adopt mandates

Results preview

- Minutes worked per day ↓
- Minutes of primary childcare/face time per day ↑
- Minutes of leisure time per day
 - ▶ Men ↑
 - ▶ Women ↓



Background: PSL laws (1)

- Recent state program: DC adopted in 2008
- November 2024: 18 states adopted or announced a PSL mandate
- Financially protected time away from work for health reasons
 - ▶ 7 days/year, can carry over
 - ▶ Own health or family responsibilities
- 100% wage replacement
- 90 days initial accrual period
- Limited burden in application

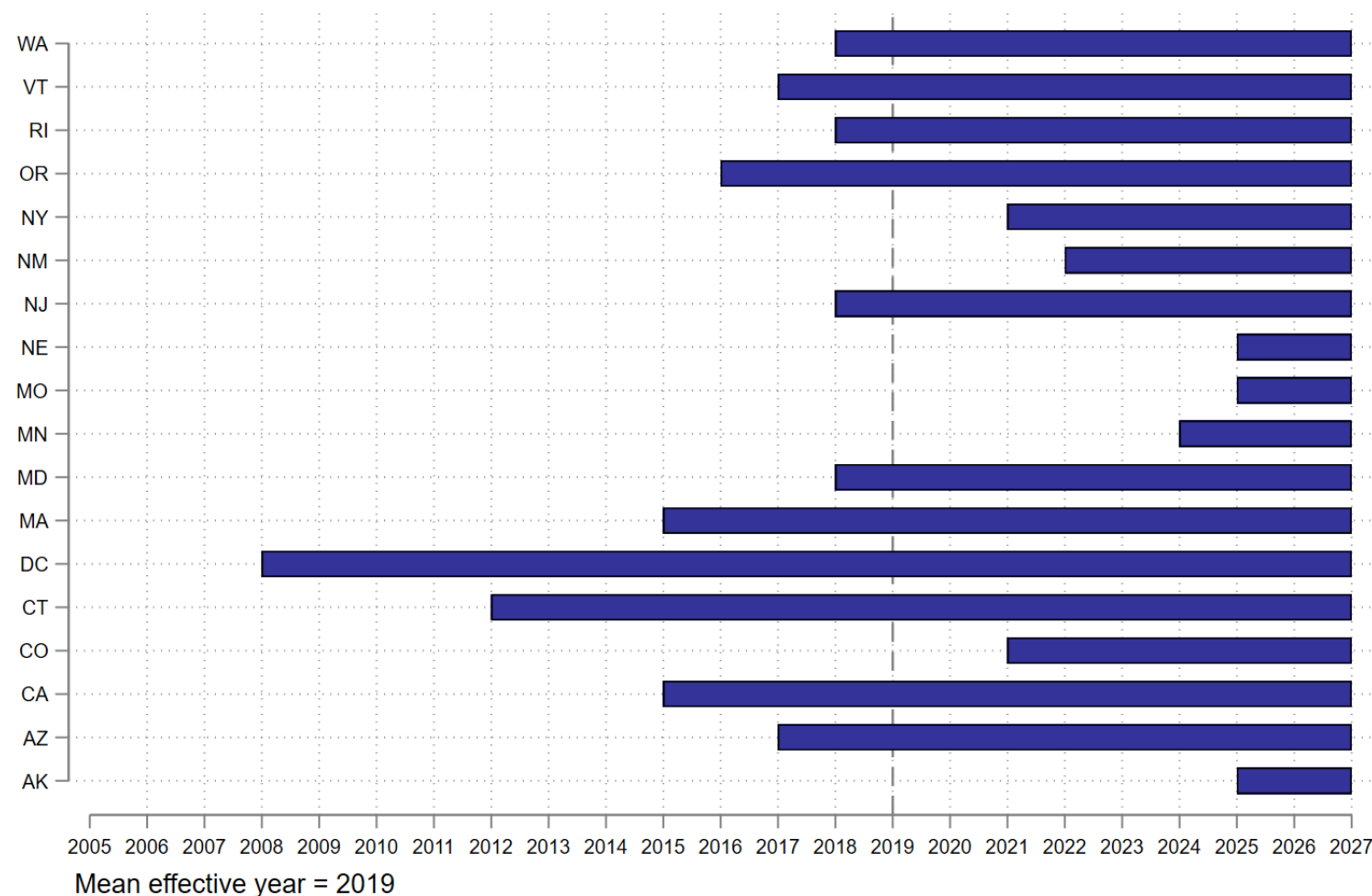


Background: PSL laws (2)

- Right to take **unpaid** sick leave
- Some states have exemptions for small employers
- Employer mandates
- Employer must post benefit details: AZ, MA
- Some localities have also adopted PSL mandates
 - ▶ First in nation: San Francisco, CA 2007

Background: Paid sick leave laws (3)

- Timing of state PSL mandates
- Source: National Partnership for Women & Families (2025)



Data (1)

- 2004–2023 American Time Use Survey (ATUS) extract from IPUMS (Flood et al. 2023)
 - ▶ Adults aged 22–59 living with minor children
 - ▶ Outcomes measured in minutes per day aggregated from daily time diaries:
 - Work and work-related activities including commuting time (first stage)
 - Primary childcare of household children
 - Routine and health, educational, and other
 - Face time with children (time in the presence of children)
 - Secondary childcare (supervisory time of children < age 13)
 - Other outcomes: Household production, sleep, & leisure

Data (2)

■ PSL mandate data

- ▶ National Partnership for Women & Families (2025)
 - State PSL mandates
- ▶ Empirical concerns with sub-state mandates
 - Location of work, not residence, salient for PSL mandates
 - Sub-state mandates easier to evade

Difference-in-differences (DID)

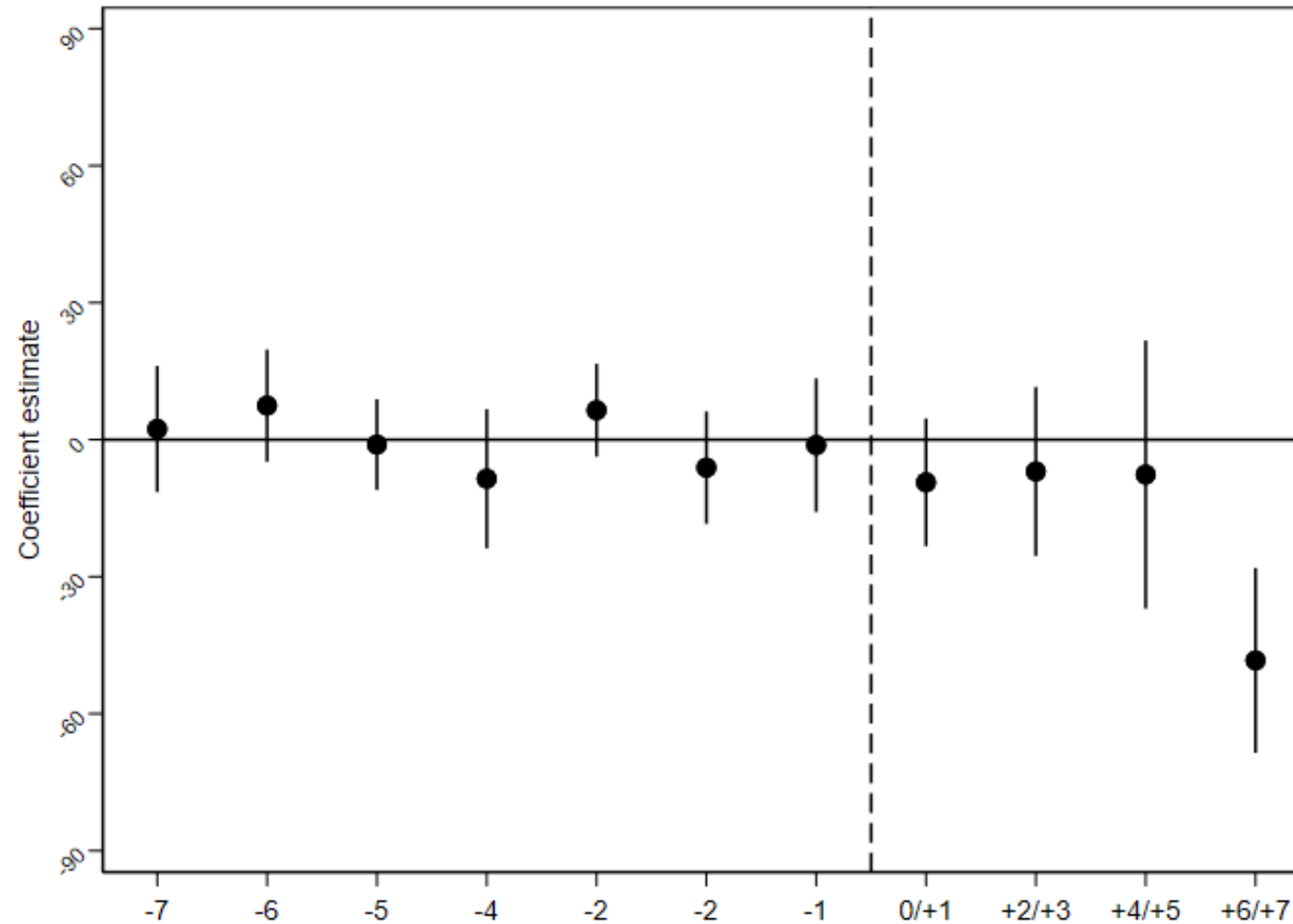
■ Two-step DID estimator proposed by Gardner (2022)

1. $Y_{i,s,t}(0) = \alpha_s + \gamma_t + Z_{s,t}\beta_1 + X_{i,s,t}\beta_2 + \varepsilon_{i,s,t}$

2. $Y_{i,s,t}(1) - \hat{Y}_{i,s,t}(0) = \delta PSL_{s,t-24} + \mu_{i,s,t}$

- Robust to bias from dynamic & heterogeneous treatment effects with a staggered policy rollout
- i = respondent, s = state, & t = month-year
- $Y_{i,s,t}$: time use outcome
- $PSL_{s,t-24}$: state PSL mandate lagged two years
- $Z_{s,t}$: state-level policies, poverty, and population
- $X_{i,s,t}$: individual-level characteristics
- $\varepsilon_{i,s,t}$ & $\mu_{i,s,t}$: error terms
- Use ATUS weights and cluster standard errors at the state level.

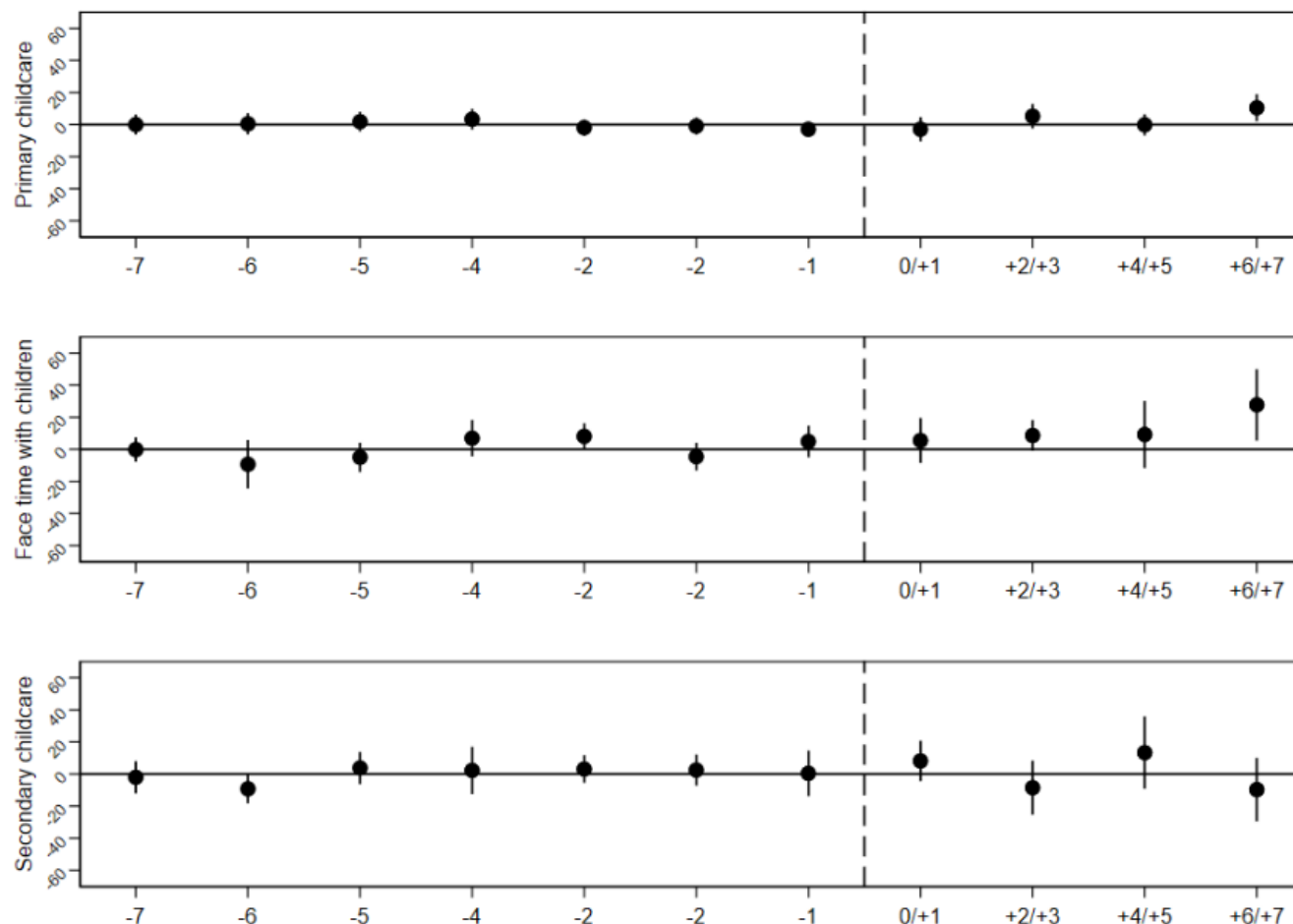
Event study for work time (min/day)



Source: ATUS; National Partnership for Women & Families

Betas & 95% CI's (unscaled)

Event studies for childcare (min/day)

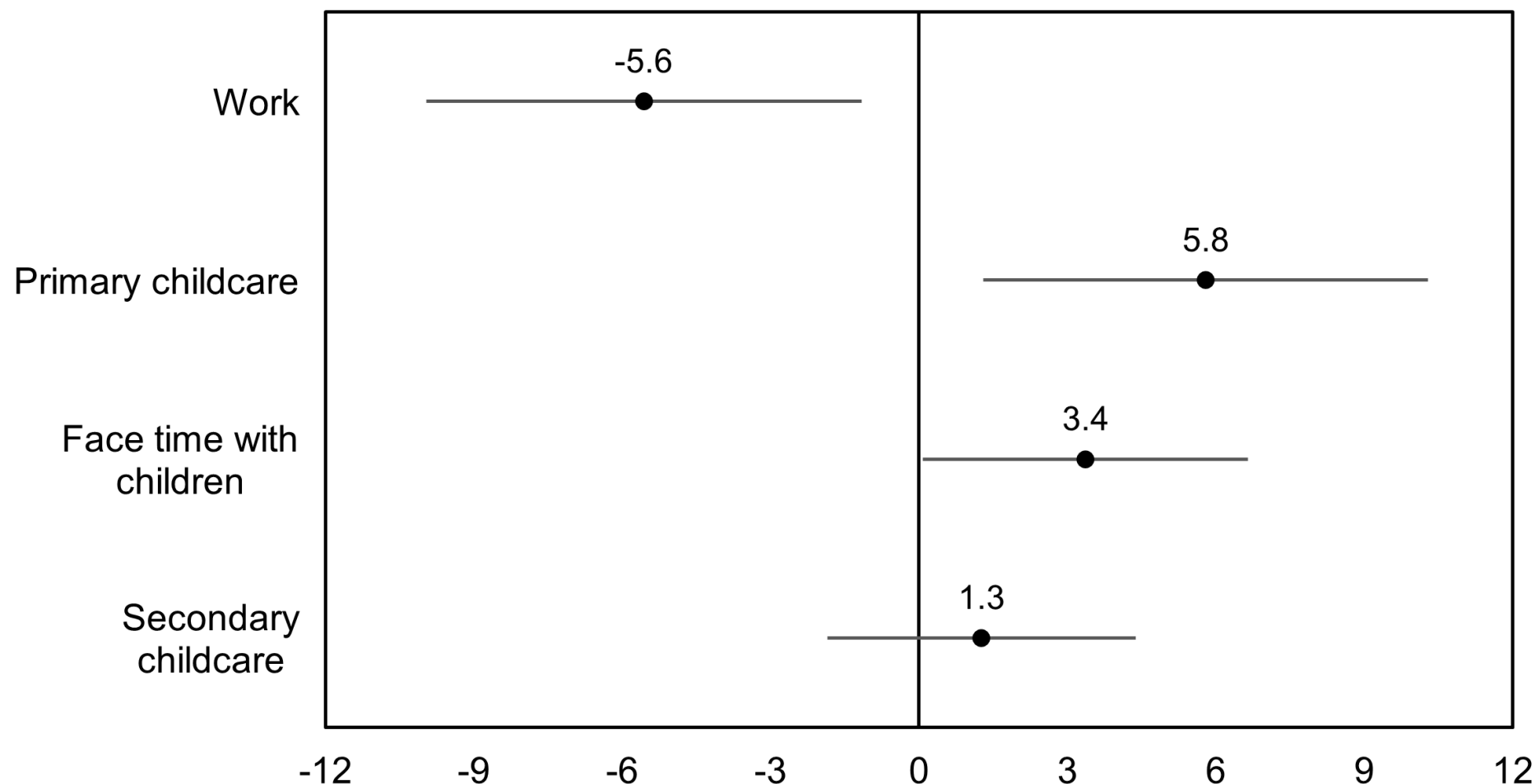


Source: ATUS; National Partnership for Women & Families

Betas & 95% CI's (unscaled)



Effect of state PSL mandates on work and childcare (%Δ min/day)

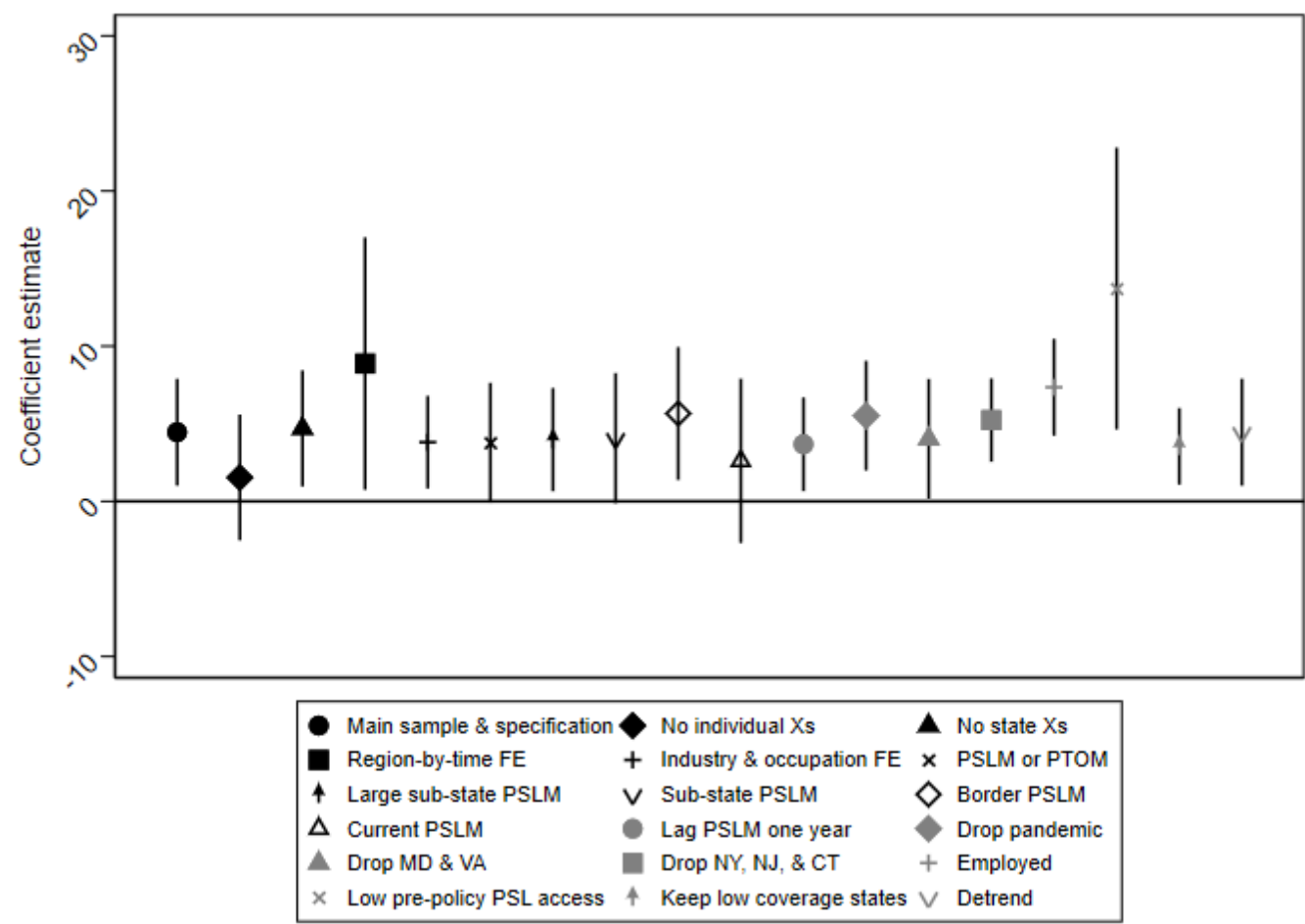


Source: ATUS; National Partnership for Women & Families

Betas & 95% CI's (scaled)



Robustness for PSL effects on primary childcare

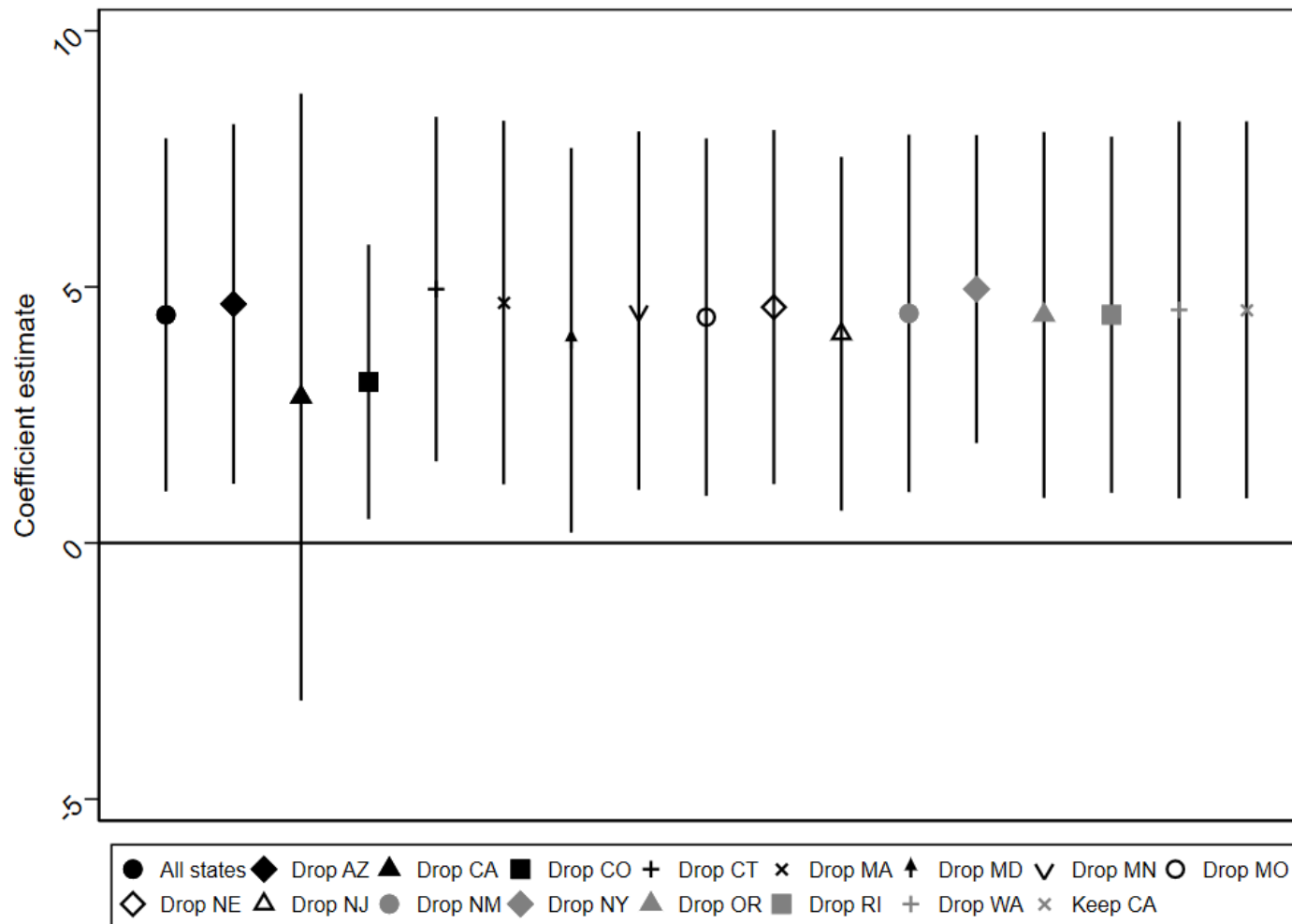


Source: ATUS; National Partnership for Women & Families

Betas & 95% CI's (unscaled)

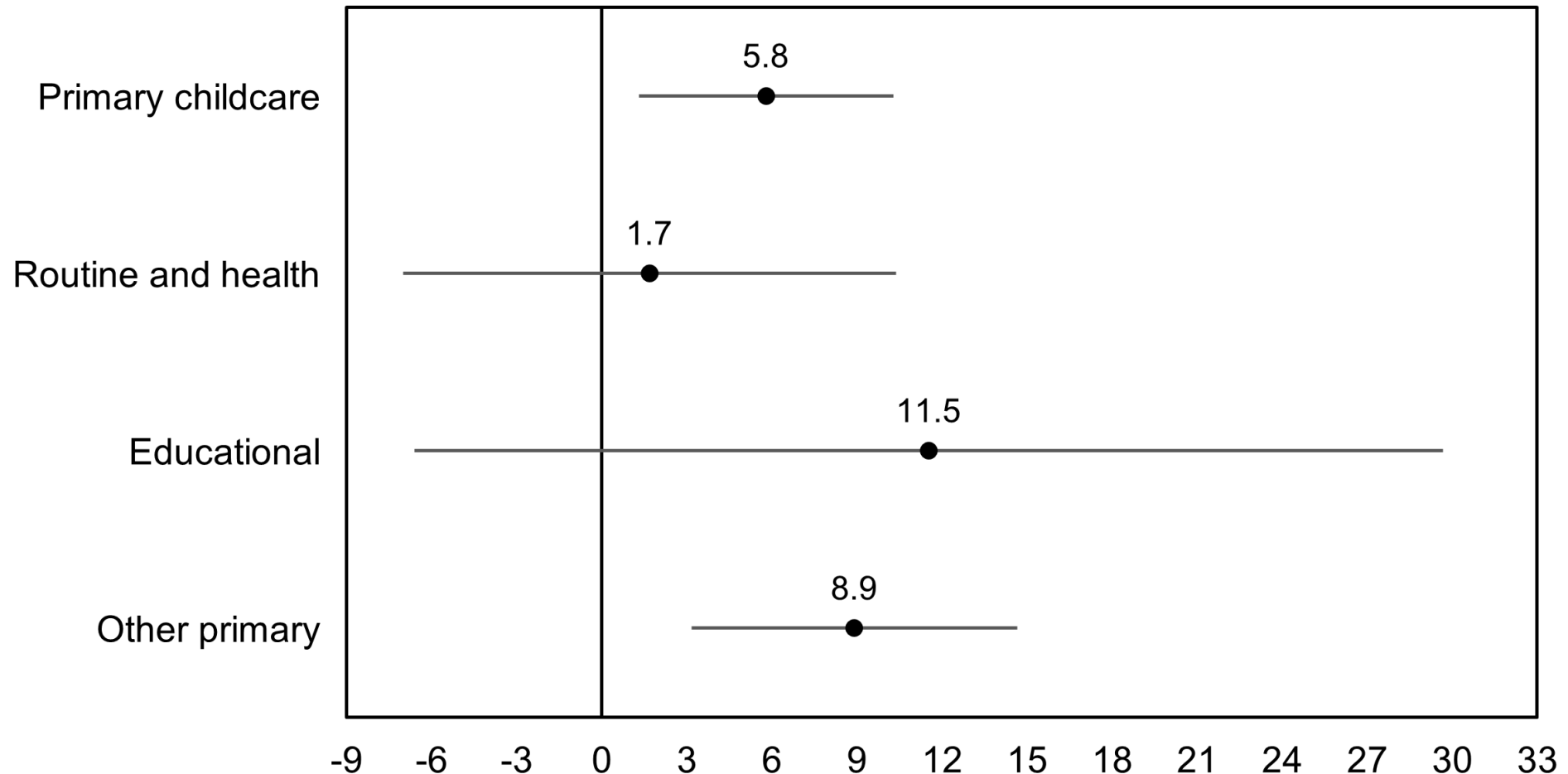


Leave-one-state-out effects (primary childcare)



Source: ATUS; National Partnership for Women & Families
 Betas & 95% CI's (unscaled)

Effect of state PSL mandates on primary childcare (%Δ min/day)

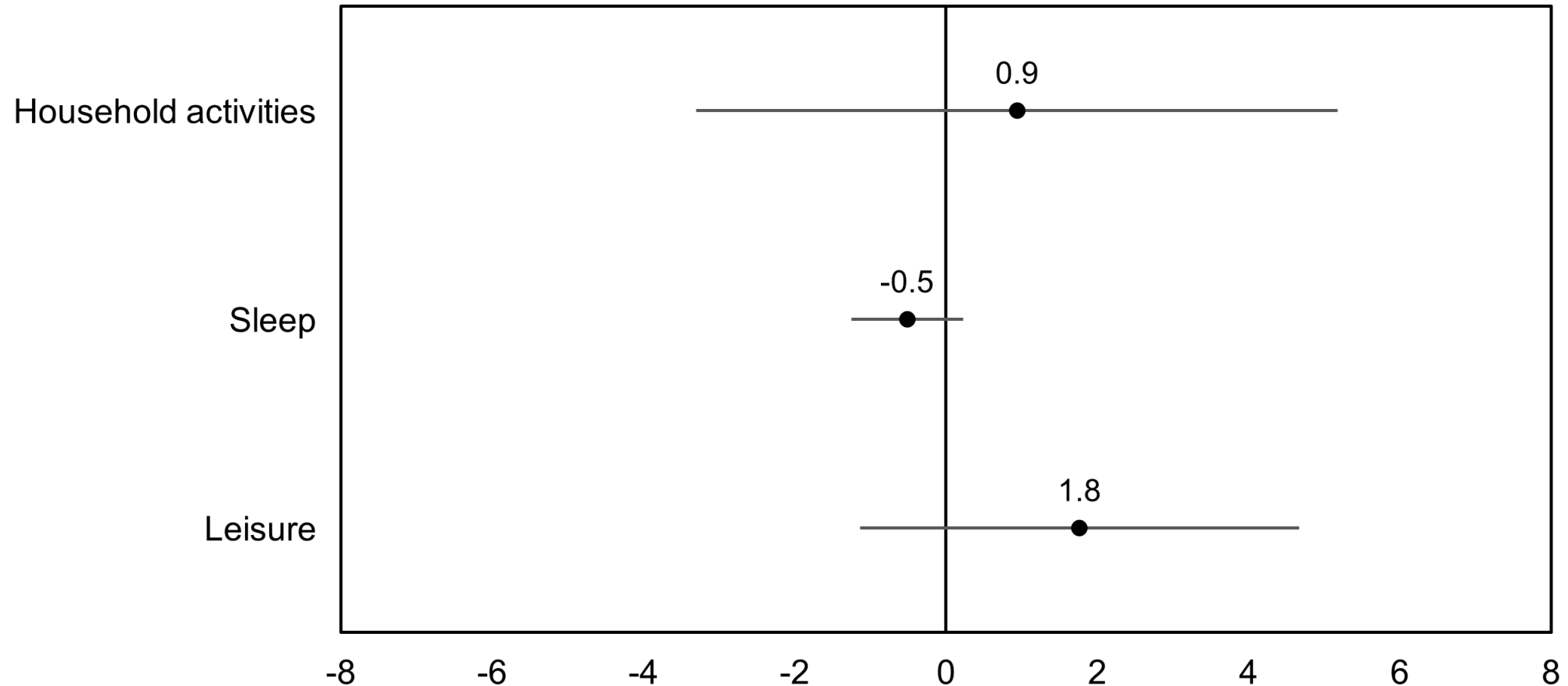


Source: ATUS; National Partnership for Women & Families

Betas & 95% CI's (scaled)



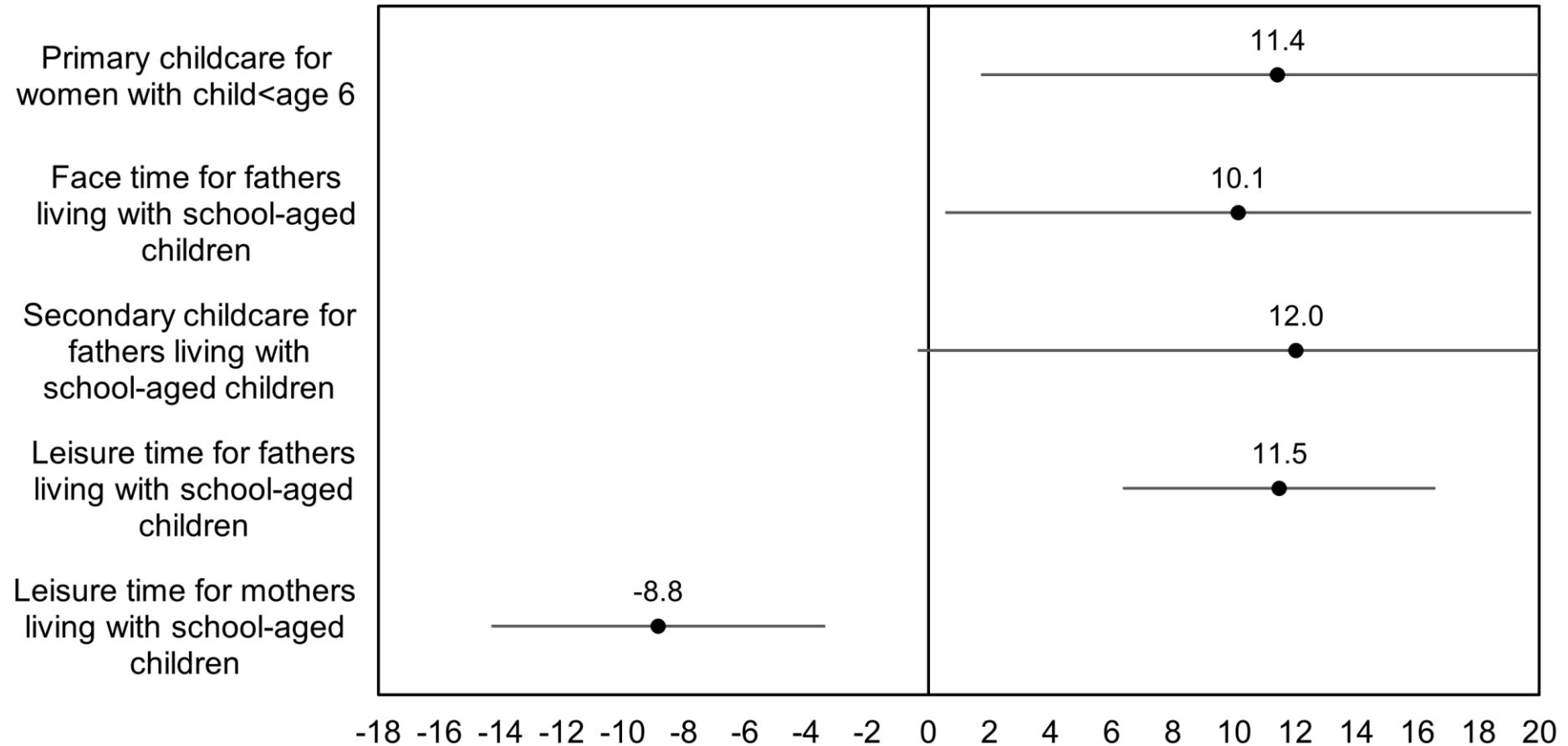
Effect of state PSL mandates on other time use (% Δ min/day)



Source: ATUS; National Partnership for Women & Families

Betas & 95% CI's (scaled)

Heterogeneity: Effect of state PSL mandates (%Δ min/day)



Source: ATUS; National Partnership for Women & Families

Betas & 95% CI's (scaled)

Effect sizes are reasonable?

■ First-stage: work ↓14.9 min/day, driven by weekdays (↓16.8 min/day)

▶ ↓ 73 hours per year

- Maclean et al. (2025) finds that workers in newly-covered jobs in the National Compensation Survey take only 20 hours of leave per year post-mandate.
 - Our measure of work time includes commuting time.
 - We consider people and not jobs as the unit of measurement.
 - Parents might work in jobs that are disproportionately affected by PSL mandates.
 - We include an additional year of data (2023), and the event studies show longer-run effects.
 - ATUS is a smaller sample and confidence intervals are large (upper end of 90% CI = ↓ 10.6 hours).

■ Second-stage:

▶ Face time with children ↑10.4 min/day

Key Findings

■ Post-state PSL mandate

- ▶ Minutes worked per day ↓
 - 5.6% decrease
- ▶ Minutes of childcare per day ↑
 - 5.8% increase in primary childcare
 - 3.4% increase in face time with children

■ Our findings suggest that state PSL mandates help parents to better balance work and childcare responsibilities.

Contact Information

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Benefit notice example: Massachusetts

EARNED SICK TIME

Notice of Employee Rights

Beginning July 1, 2015, Massachusetts employees have the right to earn and take sick leave from work.

WHO QUALIFIES?

All employees in Massachusetts can earn sick time.

This includes full-time, part-time, temporary, and seasonal employees.

HOW IS IT EARNED?

- Employees earn 1 hour of sick time for every 30 hours they work.
- Employees can earn and use up to **40 hours per year** if they work enough hours.
- Employees with unused earned sick time at the end of the year can **rollover up to 40 hours**.
- Employees **begin earning** sick time on their first day of work and **may begin using** earned sick time 90 days after starting work.

WILL IT BE PAID?

- If an employer has 11 or more employees, sick time must be paid.
- For employers with 10 or fewer employees, sick time may be unpaid.
- Paid sick time must be paid on the same schedule and at the same rate as regular wages.

WHEN CAN IT BE USED?

- An employee can use sick time when the employee or the employee's child, spouse, parent, or parent of a spouse is sick, has a medical appointment, or has to address the effects of domestic violence.
- The smallest amount of sick time an employee can take is one hour.
- Sick time cannot be used as an excuse to be late for work without advance notice of a proper use.
- Use of sick time for other purposes is not allowed and may result in an employee being disciplined.

CAN AN EMPLOYER HAVE A DIFFERENT POLICY?

Yes. Employers may have their own sick leave or paid time off policy, so long as employees can use at least the same amount of time, for the same reasons, and with the same job-protections as under the Earned Sick Time Law.

RETALIATION

- Employees using earned sick time cannot be fired or otherwise retaliated against for exercising or attempting to exercise rights under the law.
- Examples of retaliation include: denying use or delaying payment of earned sick time, firing an employee, taking away work hours, or giving the employee undesirable assignments.

NOTICE & VERIFICATION

- Employees must **notify** their employer before they use sick time, except in a emergency.
- Employers may require employees to **use a reasonable notification system** the employer creates.
- If an employee is out of work for 3 consecutive days **OR** uses sick time within 2 weeks of leaving his or her job, an employer may require documentation from a medical provider.

DO YOU HAVE QUESTIONS?

Call the Fair Labor Division at 617-727-3465 ○ Visit www.mass.gov/ago/earnedsicktime



Commonwealth of Massachusetts
Office of the Attorney General
English - July 2016

The Attorney General enforces the Earned Sick Time Law and regulations.

It is unlawful to violate any provision of the Earned Sick Time Law. Violations of any provision of the Earned Sick Time Law, M.G.L. c. 149, §148C, or these regulations, 940 CMR 33.00 shall be subject to paragraphs (1), (2), (4), (6) and (7) of subsection (b) of M.G.L. c. 149, §27C(b) and to §150.

This notice is intended to inform.

Full text of the law and regulations are available at www.mass.gov/ago/earnedsicktime.

